friends. Warning him of the losses that could result from such an endeavour, they insulted him by saying that it amounted to ‘a common crow imitating a peacock’. At this juncture S.V. Nallaperumal Pillai, an influential trader and landlord of Tuticorin, sent Joseph Louis Motha—who was not only his accountant but was also involved in the Swadeshi movement—to Bombay to arrange for a ship. It is not clear what was the arrangement being sought—lease, charter or purchase. After two months of intense effort, Motha wired his employer that the owner of Shah Line Company[14] had gone back on his word about chartering a ship. Traders backing Nallaperumal Pillai in this venture now approached VOC and pleaded with him to save the situation. Asking them to put their faith in the almighty, VOC too prayed to the god Murugan of Tiruchendur. He then sent Shah Line Company a flurry of telegrams tempting it with lucrative profits. Finally, he sent an agent by train to Bombay, and then wired Shah Line Company asking for a contract. However, as soon as the agent returned, some traders—Nallaperumal Pillai being the first—backtracked fearing the huge financial commitment. VOC recalls his own untiring efforts to convince them through various methods: pleas, persuasion, advice and scandal. Subsequently, he drafted a contract which was revised by the Shah Line Company and then signed by both parties. However, by the time Motha could reach Bombay, Nallaperumal Pillai had once again muddied matters by reneging on his agreement. It was left to VOC to bombard Shah Line Company with telegrams and convince Essaji Tajbhoy to stick to the deal. Finally, Shah Line Company confirmed by wire that the steamer would reach Colombo with Pragumal and Susai (from the names we can surmise that they were Paravas by caste) on board. As promised, within five days, the steamer did reach Colombo. Motha now rushed to Colombo to take charge of the steamer; but once again, due to some disagreements, the handing over of the steamer was delayed. At the instance of Motha, VOC himself proceeded to Colombo, resolved the differences and arrived triumphantly at Tuticorin. As we saw, the first steamers had arrived in April 1906. From this description, we can surmise that these efforts had begun early in that year.